never being sure at what notice I'm going to be needed and feeling like some sort of sacrificial target for the game's most challenging situations, usually when my body is already complaining about the work load. Despite feeling like I have surely earned some sort of seniority pass to throw someone who isn't the leader of the bowling attack out there to get hit, I have learned to suck it up. If it's what the team needs, it's what I'm prepared to do.

I am not nightwatchman today, but Joe Root at the other end is in need of someone to hang around at the crease with him. Joe has an extremely calm presence to him. He exudes nothing but a lightness of touch when he bats. From the moment he walked into the England team, the more intense the battle or the situation, the more Joe smiled. He loves being in a fight – it brings some sort of youthful playfulness out of him rather than hyper anxiety. He is beautiful to watch too – a mixture of all the best elements of traditional, aesthetic batting and an electric knack for improvisation and modernity.

When I get to the crease, he punches gloves with me, smiling, and very simply tells me the plan, as if it's a shopping list he's asked me to go out and get for him. He'll bat for four balls, then rotate the strike and give me two balls to face. I nod, my expression complete with the concerned inward-facing eyebrows that seem only to muscle themselves on to my face when I'm out to bat, twitching as I do. For the first of my two balls, Joe's seeming to find the gap at will every time he needs the single and a couple of overs later, I'm already beginning to feel less anxious than I usually would. Jadeja runs around the wicket and bowls to me and, as he drops the ball short, I drop my hands, turn them around, effecting a reverse sweep and hit the ball behind square for four. For a second, the reverse sweep has my hands around the other way, almost appearing right-handed just for the split-second in the shot. Maybe Trescothick was half right? It's as close to a natural cricket shot as I've ever felt myself play. The crowd goes up in cheers, ones I would find semi-sarcastic, slightly patronising usually, but here it feels like everyone is remembering a month earlier, that Sri Lanka defeat still in the air, and something is due to be exorcised.

Shami bowls around the wicket, running out from behind the umpire, and I am punching him on the back foot for four. It feels like the shot of a proper batter. I do not celebrate, or let on how much I have enjoyed it. It's